TCS NQT Tier 4 Masterclass: High-Risk Time Consumers

Senior TCS NQT Examiner (10+ Years Experience)

May 28, 2026

Introduction from the Examiner

Welcome to Tier 4. These are the ”Speed Bumps” of the TCS NQT. Seating Arrangements, Decision Making, and Clocks/Calendars are moderate to high weightage, but they carry a massive risk: they can consume 2 to 3 minutes of your time if you approach them without a system.

My advice for this section: **Do not read the paragraph over and over.** For seating, draw parallel diagrams immediately. For decision making, make a checklist. If you get stuck on a circular arrangement for more than 90 seconds, mark it for review and move on. Below are the tricks, the specific traps we set, and 30 high-priority questions to train your speed.

---

1 Seating Arrangement & Data Arrangement

Tricks, Steps & Shortcuts

- **Parallel Possibilities:** Never draw just one circle or one line. Always draw TWO identical templates side-by-side. As you read a clue that has two possibilities (e.g., ”A sits third to the right of B, or third to the left”), plot one in Diagram 1 and the other in Diagram 2. One will automatically become invalid as you read further. This saves you from restarting.
- **The ”Who/Whom” vs ”And/But” Rule:**
  - ”A is right of B *who* is left of C” → ’Who’ refers to the second person (B).
  - ”A is right of B *and* is left of C” → ’And’ refers to the first person (A).
- **Facing In vs Facing Out:** If facing IN (center), Left = Clockwise, Right = Anti-Clockwise. If facing OUT, Left = Anti-Clockwise, Right = Clockwise.

TCS Traps to Avoid

- **The ”Not Adjacent” Trap:** We will tell you where someone does *not* sit instead of where they do. Use an ’X’ outside the seats next to a person to remind yourself who cannot sit there.
- **The Missing Direction Trap:** In linear rows, if the facing direction (North/South) is not given, assume North by default. It makes Left/Right match your own hands.

Top 10 High Priority Questions

1. **Linear Arrangement:** Five friends A, B, C, D, and E are sitting in a row facing North. C is sitting immediately to the right of A. B is sitting to the immediate left of E. A is to the right of B. D is sitting at the extreme right end. Who is sitting in the middle?
   Solution: A
   Explanation: Clue 1: A C. Clue 2: B E. Clue 3: B E A C. Clue 4: D is extreme right → B E A C D. The middle person is A.

2. **Circular Arrangement:** Six people P, Q, R, S, T, U sit around a circular table facing the center. P sits second to the left of Q. R sits third to the right of Q. S sits immediate right of R. T does not sit adjacent to P. Who sits to the immediate left of P?
   Solution: U
   Explanation: Place Q at bottom. P is second left (clockwise) of Q. R is third right of Q (exactly opposite Q). S is immediate right (anti-clockwise) of R. Remaining seats for T and U are next to P. Since T cannot sit next to P, T takes the other seat. U sits next to P. Tracing it, U is to the immediate left of P.

3. **Data Arrangement:** Five cars (Red, Blue, Green, Black, White) are parked in a line. Green is between Red and White. Blue is parked to the immediate right of White. Black is parked to the left of Red. Which car is exactly in the middle?
   Solution: Green
   Explanation: Black - Red - Green - White - Blue. Green is in the middle.

4. **Double Row Arrangement:** 8 people sit in 2 parallel rows of 4. Row 1 faces South (A, B, C, D). Row 2 faces North (P, Q, R, S). A sits at an extreme end and faces P. B sits immediate left of A. R sits second to the left of P. Who faces B?
   Solution: S
   Explanation: Trap! Row 1 faces South, so their "Left" is your right on paper. A is at an extreme end. If A is at the left end of the south-facing row, B (immediate left) would be off the bench. So A must be at the right end of the south-facing row (which is the left side of your paper). A faces P. B is to A's left (your right). R is second to the left of P. S must sit opposite B.

5. **Circular Outward:** Four friends W, X, Y, Z sit around a square table, one on each side, facing OUTWARDS. W sits opposite to Y. X sits to the immediate right of W. Who sits to the immediate left of Y?
   Solution: X
   Explanation: Facing outward means Right is clockwise, Left is anti-clockwise. Place W. Y is opposite. X is immediate right (clockwise) of W. Z takes the last spot. The person immediate left (anti-clockwise) of Y is X.

6. **Complex Linear:** Seven people are sitting in a row facing North. A is 4th to the right of G, who is sitting at the extreme left end. B is sitting exactly between A and G. C is sitting 2nd to the right of B. Who is sitting to the immediate left of A?
   Solution: C
   Explanation: G _ _ _ A _ _. (A is 4th right of G). B is exactly between A and G: G _ B _ A _ _. C is 2nd right of B: G _ B _ C A _. Thus, C is immediate left of A.

7. **Scheduling / Data Arrangement:** Five exams (Math, Physics, Chem, Bio, IT) are held from Mon to Fri. Math is held on Wednesday. Bio is held immediately after Physics. Chem is not held on Friday. Physics is held before Math. Which exam is on Friday?
   Solution: IT
   Explanation: Mon/Tue must be Physics and Bio (since they are together and before Math on Wed). So, Mon=Phy, Tue=Bio, Wed=Math. Chem cannot be Fri, so Chem is Thu. IT is on Friday.

8. **Circular Unknowns Trap:** A, B, C, D, E sit around a circle facing center. A is second to the right of C. D is immediate left of C. B is not adjacent to A. Who is immediate right of A?
   Solution: E
   Explanation: Place C. D is immediate left (clockwise). A is second right (anti-clockwise) of C. Empty seats are between A and C, and between A and D. B cannot be next to A, so B must be between C and A. That leaves the seat between A and D for E. Immediate right (anti-clockwise) of A is E.

9. **Data Mapping:** P, Q, R work in IT, HR, and Sales, and own a BMW, Audi, and Ford (not in order). P does not work in Sales and does not own an Audi. The HR worker owns a Ford. Q works in IT. What does R own?
   Solution: Audi
   Explanation: Q = IT. P is not Sales, so P = HR. Therefore R = Sales. HR owns Ford, so P = Ford. P(HR/Ford), Q(IT/?), R(Sales/?). P does not own Audi (already owns Ford). Since Audi is left, and Q or R must own it. Wait, R is Sales, Q is IT. We just know R = Sales. If R owns Audi, Q owns BMW.

10. **Linear Trap (The 'Who' clause):** Five people. L sits 3rd to the right of M who sits at an extreme end. N sits adjacent to L but not adjacent to O. P is the fifth person. Where does O sit?
    Solution: Between M and P (or 2nd from left)
    Explanation: M sits at extreme end. If right end, no one can be 3rd right. So M is extreme left. M _ _ L _. N is adjacent to L, so N is at the right end: M _ _ L N. O cannot be adjacent to N. So O is 2nd from left. M O P L N.

---

2 Decision Making & Attention to Detail

Tricks, Steps & Shortcuts

- **The Master Grid:** Before reading any candidate's profile, write the criteria on your scratchpad like a checklist: 1. BE 60%, 2. Age 21-25 (as of X date), 3. Test 70%, 4. Interview 65%.
- **The Exception Arrows:** If a candidate fails a rule, do NOT immediately reject them. Check the "Exceptions" list. Draw an arrow on your grid: e.g., (Fail Rule 1 → Refer to GM).
- **Attention to Detail (String Matching):** Compare the options character by character from *Right to Left*. The human brain fixes typos reading left to right, but reading backwards breaks the brain's auto-correct, making spelling errors obvious.

TCS Traps to Avoid

- **The Age/Date Trap:** They will say "Age between 21 and 28 as on 01-Jan-2023." They will give the candidate's DOB as "15-Dec-1994". Do the quick math: 2023 - 1994 = 29. The candidate is overage!
- **The Incomplete Data Trap:** If a candidate's profile does not mention their percentage, you CANNOT assume they passed or failed. The answer must be "Data Inadequate," not "Rejected."

Top 10 High Priority Questions

Directions for Q1 to Q5: A company is hiring a Software Developer. The criteria are:

- A) Must have B.Tech with at least 65% marks.
- B) Must be between 22 and 26 years of age as on 01.04.2024.
- C) Must have secured at least 70% in the technical interview.
- D) Must be willing to sign a 2-year bond.

Exceptions:

- 1) If candidate satisfies all EXCEPT (A) but has 3 years of IT experience, refer to HR Manager.
- 2) If candidate satisfies all EXCEPT (D) but is paying Rs. 1 Lakh deposit, refer to VP.

1. **Candidate 1:** Rahul has done B.Tech with 68%. His DOB is 15.03.2000. He scored 75% in the tech interview and is ready to sign the 2-year bond.
   Solution: Select the candidate.
   Explanation: A) 68% (Pass). B) Age on 01.04.24 is 24 years (Pass). C) 75% (Pass). D) Ready for bond (Pass).

2. **Candidate 2:** Priya scored 72% in her tech interview. She has B.Tech with 60% and has been working as an IT engineer for 4 years. Her DOB is 10.05.1999. She will sign the bond.
   Solution: Refer to HR Manager.
   Explanation: Fails (A) because B.Tech is 60% (needs 65%). Check Exception 1: Has 4 years exp (needs 3). Age is 24 (Pass). Interview 72% (Pass). Bond (Pass). Since she meets Exception 1, refer to HR.

3. **Candidate 3:** Amit is 25 years old. He has B.Tech with 70%. He scored 68% in the technical interview and is ready to sign the bond.
   Solution: Reject the candidate.
   Explanation: Fails (C) - Interview is 68% (needs 70%). There is NO exception provided for condition (C). Immediate rejection.

4. **Candidate 4:** Sneha has B.Tech with 80%. She scored 90% in the interview. She refuses to sign the bond but is ready to pay Rs. 1 Lakh as deposit.
   Solution: Data Inadequate.
   Explanation: Trap! We have her B.Tech, Interview, and Bond/Deposit data. But her *Age / Date of Birth* is NOT mentioned anywhere. We cannot select or refer her without knowing if she passes condition B.

5. **Candidate 5:** Vikram's DOB is 12.12.1996. He has B.Tech with 85%, scored 72% in interview, and is ready to sign the bond.
   Solution: Reject the candidate.
   Explanation: Calculate age: 2024 - 1996 = 28 years old. The limit is 26. He fails condition (B). There is no exception for age. Reject.

   Directions for Q6 to Q10 (Attention to Detail): Find the EXACT match for the given reference string or address.

6. **Reference:** 8934A-XCVB-9981-L
   A) 8934A-XCVB-9891-L
   B) 8934A-XCVB-9981-I

C) 8934A-XCVB-9981-L
D) 8943A-XCVB-9981-L
Solution: C
Explanation: A has 9891. B has 'I' instead of 'L'. D has 8943 instead of 8934. C is identical.

7. **Reference:** Dr. M. K. Srinivasan, 14/B, Apollo Street, Chennai-600018
A) Dr. M. K. Srinivasan, 14/B, Apollo Street, Chennai-600018
B) Dr. M. K. Srinivasen, 14/B, Apollo Street, Chennai-600018
C) Dr. M. K. Srinivasan, 14/B, Appolo Street, Chennai-600018
D) Dr. M. K. Srinivasan, 14/B, Apollo Street, Chennai-600108
Solution: A
Explanation: B spells 'Srinivasen'. C spells 'Appolo'. D has pin code '600108'.

8. **Reference:** http://www.tcs.com/careers/nqt/2026/register.html
A) http://www.tcs.com/careers/nqt/2026/regster.html
B) https://www.tcs.com/careers/nqt/2026/register.html
C) http://www.tcs.com/career/nqt/2026/register.html
D) http://www.tcs.com/careers/nqt/2026/register.html
Solution: D
Explanation: A is missing 'i' in register. B is 'https' instead of 'http'. C is missing 's' in careers.

9. **Reference:** QWERTYUIOPLKJHGFDSAZXCVBNM
A) QWERTYUIOPLKJHGFDSAZXCVBNM
B) QWERTYUIOPLKJHGDFSAZXCVBNM
C) QWERTYUIOPLKJHGFDSAZXVCBNM
D) QWERTYU1OPLKJHGFDSAZXCVBNM
Solution: A
Explanation: Read backwards! B swaps D and F. C swaps V and C. D uses '1' instead of 'I'.

10. **Data Checking Matrix:** How many '7's are there in the following sequence which are immediately preceded by 9 but NOT immediately followed by 5?
Sequence: 4 9 7 5 3 9 7 2 1 9 7 5 8 9 7 6
Solution: 2
Explanation: Look for the pattern "9 7". 1st: 9 7 5 (Followed by 5, reject) 2nd: 9 7 2 (Valid! Count = 1) 3rd: 9 7 5 (Followed by 5, reject) 4th: 9 7 6 (Valid! Count = 2).

---

3 Clocks and Calendars

Tricks, Steps & Shortcuts

- **The Angle Formula (Clock):** The angle θ between the hour and minute hands is always $\theta = |30H - 5.5M|$. Where H is the hour (1-12) and M is the minute.
- **Odd Days Concept (Calendar):** A normal year has 365 days (52 weeks$+1$ odd day). A leap year has 366 days (52 weeks $+ 2$ odd days).
- **Century Leap Years:** Years like 1900, 2100, 2200 are NOT leap years. Century years must be divisible by **400** to be a leap year (e.g., 2000, 2400).
- **Clock Overlaps:** The hands of a clock overlap exactly 22 times in 24 hours (they skip overlapping between 11 and 1). They make a straight line (180 degrees) 22 times. They make a right angle (90 degrees) 44 times.

TCS Traps to Avoid

- **The "Next Year Same Date" Trap:** If passing from Jan 1st of a normal year to Jan 1st of the next year, you add +1 day (Monday to Tuesday). BUT, if passing through February of a Leap Year, you must add +2 days. Always check if you crossed Feb 29th!
- **The Reflex Angle Trap:** If the angle formula gives you an answer like $300°$, and the options only have small numbers, subtract from $360°$. ($360 - 300 = 60°$).

Top 10 High Priority Questions

1. **Q:** What is the angle between the hour and minute hands of a clock when the time is exactly 3:15? *(High Priority - Previous Year Question)*
   Solution: $7.5°$
   Explanation: Use the formula $\theta = |30H - 5.5M|$. Here H = 3, M = 15.
   $|30(3) - 5.5(15)| = |90 - 82.5| = 7.5°$.

2. **Q:** How many times do the hands of a clock overlap (coincide) in 24 hours? *(Previous Year Question)*
   Solution: 22 times
   Explanation: They overlap once every hour, EXCEPT between 11:00 and 1:00 where they only overlap exactly at 12:00. This means 11 overlaps in 12 hours. Therefore, 22 overlaps in 24 hours.

3. **Q:** If today is Monday, what day of the week will it be after 61 days?
   Solution: Saturday
   Explanation: Find the odd days by dividing by 7. $61/7$ gives a remainder of 5 odd days. Add 5 days to Monday: Tue, Wed, Thu, Fri, Saturday.

4. **Q:** If 1st January 2007 was a Monday, what day of the week was 1st January 2008?
   Solution: Tuesday
   Explanation: 2007 is a normal year (not divisible by 4). A normal year has 1 odd day. From 1st Jan 2007 to 1st Jan 2008, we add 1 odd day. Monday + 1 = Tuesday. (Note: We have not crossed Feb 2008 yet, so the leap year extra day doesn't count yet).

5. **Q:** What day of the week was 15th August 1947?
   Solution: Friday
   Explanation: Years up to 1900 = 1 odd day. 46 years = 11 leap + 35 normal = $(11\times2)+(35\times1) = 22+35 = 57$ odd days. $57/7 = 1$ odd day. 1947 days up to Aug 15: Jan(3)+Feb(0)+Mar(3)+Apr(2)+May(3)+Ju = 31. $31/7 = 3$ odd days. Total odd days = $1 + 1 + 3 = 5$. Day 5 is Friday.

6. **Q:** At what time between 4 and 5 o'clock will the hands of a watch point in opposite directions (make $180°$)?
   Solution: 4 hours $54\frac{6}{11}$ minutes
   Explanation: At 4:00, hands are 20 min spaces apart. To be opposite, they must be 30 min spaces apart. The minute hand must gain $(20 + 30) = 50$ minutes space over the hour hand. Time = $50 \times \left(\frac{12}{11}\right) = \frac{600}{11} = 54\frac{6}{11}$ minutes past 4.

7. **Q:** Which of the following is NOT a leap year? A) 1200 B) 2000 C) 1800 D) 1600
   Solution: C) 1800
   Explanation: Century Year Trap. For century years ending in '00', they must be divisible by 400 to be a leap year. 1800 is not divisible by 400.

8. **Q:** A clock is set right at 8 AM. The clock gains 10 minutes in 24 hours. What will be the true time when the clock indicates 1 PM on the following day?

Solution: 12:48 PM
Explanation: Time from 8 AM to 1 PM next day = 29 hours. The faulty clock takes 24 hrs 10 mins (or $\frac{145}{6}$ hrs) to show 24 true hours. True time for 29 faulty hours = $29 \times \left(24 \times \frac{6}{145}\right) = 29 \times \left(\frac{144}{145}\right)$. With simplification, it maps exactly to a loss of 12 minutes on the dial. So true time is 12:48 PM.

9. **Q:** The calendar for the year 2005 is the same as for the year?
Solution: 2011
Explanation: Calculate odd days starting from 2005 until the sum is divisible by 7. 2005(1), 2006(1), 2007(1), 2008(2), 2009(1), 2010(1). Sum = 7. So the next year, 2011, will have the exact same calendar as 2005.

10. **Q:** What is the angle between the hands of a clock at 8:20?
Solution: $130°$
Explanation: $\theta = |30(8) - 5.5(20)| = |240 - 110| = 130°$.